

systems used to play video games are known as platforms; examples of these are personal computers and video game consoles. These platforms range from large mainframe computers to small handheld devices. Specialised video games such as arcade games, which were common earlier, have gradually declined in use.

The input device used to manipulate video games is called game controller, and it varies across platforms. For example, a dedicated console controller might consist of only a button and a joystick. Another may feature a dozen buttons and one or more joysticks. Earlier, personal computer games often needed a keyboard for game play or the user had to buy a separate joystick with at least one button. Many of today's computer games allow, or even require, the player to use a keyboard and mouse simultaneously.

Video games also use other ways of providing interaction and information to the player. Audio is almost universal, using sound reproduction devices such as speakers and headphones. Other feedback, such as vibration or force feedback, may be through haptic peripherals, with vibration sometimes used to simulate force feedback.

Smart homes

Scientists and engineers have found new ways to use technology in order to make our lives easier. The stuff of cutting-edge scientific research today is tomorrow's household technology.

Setting up cameras in the kitchen to record each step in cooking could



Smart home

help cooks pick up where they left off if distracted. An electronic picture could use symbols to convey a wealth of information—the more the stripes on the barber pole, the more the traffic on the way home. A camera worn around a person's neck could interpret gestures and transmit them to electronic devices, replacing the need for remote controls. Sensors could detect whether someone is in your home. You can check this anywhere from any computer.

Wearable computers would be commonplace, and you may finally be able to replace those bulky remote controls with a watch that lets you change TV channels with a flick of the wrist. A new gesture watch has four sensors and can recognise hand gestures to control a TV, lights, DVD/MP3 player or just about anything.

Interactive Media Technology

Center at Georgia Institute of Technology has developed a wearable device for home automation control and medical monitoring. The Gesture Pendant allows ordinary household devices to be controlled with the wave of a hand, making it possible to replace remotes with simple hand gestures. The user wears a small pendant that contains a wireless camera, and makes gestures in front of the pendant to control anything from a home theatre system to lighting. The pendant system can also analyse the user's movement, looking for signs of loss of motor skill or tremors in his hands, and observe daily activities to determine whether the user has been eating regularly and moving around.

Gesture-driven computers

Previous attempts to bring interactive TV functionality and exclusive

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